

aspirations. The agitation on this subject grew so strong during this period that, on 20th August 1917, the Secretary of State for India announced that the policy of His Majesty's Government, with which the Government of India was in complete accord, was that of *increasing association of Indians in every branch of Indian administration*. The policy of the Public Service Commission of 1887 which was so vehemently upheld by Curzon and his successors was thus officially buried and a new era of rapid Indianisation of the Education Department set in. For instance consider the following statistics:

	1921-22
No. of Posts in I.E.S. (Men) held by	
Europeans	200
Indians	120
Vacant	53
Total	373
No. of Posts in I.E.S. (Women) held by	
Europeans	31
Indians	2
Vacant	9
Total	42

The situation had, therefore, begun to improve considerably when the period under review came to a close.

National Education: One of the most significant developments of this period was the birth of the concept of national education. This does not, of course, mean that the ideal of national education was not put forward at all in the nineteenth century. As shown already in Chapter V, the enquiry of the Indian Education Commission in 1882-83 led to a nation-wide awakening of educational thought and even at this early date, educated Indians came forward to give their evidence before the Commission and stress the need to correct some of the defects of Indian education such as absence of religious education, slow progress of mass education, etc. This critical attitude towards the official system became more and more pronounced as time passed and several

private institutions came into existence which professed to have a *national outlook* because they differed in some respects from the Government or missionary schools and colleges. The most common of these characteristics were (a) Indian management; (b) a spirit of sacrifice on the part of the founders and teachers of the institution; (c) provision for religious education; (d) provision of some courses (over and above the usual courses recognised by the universities and the Education Departments) to meet the special cultural needs of the Indian people; (e) a keener study of the oriental classical languages chiefly intended to create self-respect and a love for past traditions and to show that Eastern civilisation was at least as good as, if not better than, the Western; (f) greater attention to modern Indian languages; and (g) lower fees. But it must be noted that all these institutions worked *within* the official system in so far as they submitted to Departmental inspection and received grants-in-aid. They were, in fact, attempts to correct a few blemishes of the official system and not the signs of an uncompromising revolt against it. Very often, they were sectarian in character and to that extent, less truly national.

It was Lord Curzon's administration and policies that gave rise, not only to a new militant nationalism, but to national education as well. The *Swadeshi* Movement was born immediately after the partition of Bengal and although it was economic in origin and application, its spirit affected every walk of life. A demand for *Swadeshi* education soon began to be put forward and was immeasurably strengthened by the repeated conflicts with the official policies and the utter failure of Indians to make the officials realise the Indian point of view in education. Between 1905 and 1921, therefore, we find a great ferment of educational thought within the fold of the Indian struggle for freedom. Of course, this early period shows a certain lack of clarity in ideas. This is but natural, for precision and definiteness usually come after the lapse of time and adequate experimentation. But in spite of this defect, the controversies of the period on the subject of national education are of great interest from the point of view of future developments.

On one point, almost all national thinkers were agreed; they all condemned the existing official system of education as

unhelpful, and even antagonistic, to national development. When, however, it came to defining precisely what the new national education ought to be, opinions were naturally not so unanimous. But even so, certain fundamental principles of national education came to be universally accepted in a short time. These were, of course, inspired by the reaction to some salient defects of the official system and may be stated as follows:

(a) *Indian Control*: Nationalist India resented the British control of Indian educational policies first and foremost, and demanded the substitution of Indian control. National education, therefore, was defined as one which, in the words of Mrs. Besant,

must be controlled by Indians shaped by Indians, carried on by Indians. It must hold up Indian ideals of devotion, wisdom and morality, and must be permeated by the Indian religious spirit rather than fed on the letter of the creeds. The spirit is spacious, tolerant, all-embracing, and recognizes that man goes to God along many roads and that all the prophets came from Him.¹

(b) *Teaching the Love of Motherland*: Secondly, it was felt that national education must inculcate love and reverence for the motherland and for her glorious traditions. As Mrs. Besant wrote:

National education must live in an atmosphere of proud and glorious patriotism, and this atmosphere must be kept sweet, fresh, and bracing by the study of Indian literature, Indian History, Indian triumphs in science, in art, in politics, in war, in colonization, in manufactures, in trade, in commerce.²

(c) *No Servile Imitation*: Thirdly, the official attempt to imitate England, to thrust English ideals on India, to create a new class of persons who would be *Indians in blood and colour but English in everything else*, was keenly resented. National leaders, therefore, pointed out that the old ideal of *spreading western*

¹Lala Lajpat Rai: *op. cit.*, pp. 28-29.

²*Ibid.*, p. 29.

science and literature which was enunciated by the Despatch of 1854 and had held the field ever since, was now obsolete and had to be completely revised. "National education," wrote Mrs. Besant,

must meet the national temperament at every point, and develop the national character. India is not to become a lesser—nor even a greater—England, but to evolve into a mightier India. British ideals are good for Britain, but it is India's ideals that are good for India. We do not want echoes nor monotones; we want a choral melody of nations, mirroring the varied qualities of Nature and of God. Shall Nature show but a single colour, and trees, and flowers, and mountains, and sky wear but a single hue? Harmonious variety and not monotony is the mark of perfection. Away from all apologies for India, with all deprecatory explanations of India's ways and customs, and traditions. India is herself, and needs not to be justified; for verily, God has evolved no greater, no more exquisite nationality than India's among all the broken reflections of His own perfect beauty.¹

This statement should not, however, be interpreted to indicate a narrow nationalist outlook impervious to all influences from outside. In the heat of the political controversies of this period, people did not always maintain their balance. The study of Indian history became a tool in the national struggle for freedom rather than an impartial search after truth; all sorts of fantastic claims were put forward on behalf of ancient India to counteract the general denunciation, based on the racial arrogance or bias or prejudice of the ruling race; and an ultra-narrow nationalism often asserted that India had nothing to learn from the West. But these excesses were really due to the intensive political conflicts of this period and sane thinkers among the glorification of the past should operate. In fact, all that the nationalists contended, therefore, was this: (i) there was no justification for the wholesale condemnation of India's past and traditions; (ii) India could rightly feel proud of her past; (iii) in the field of international culture, India was not merely a beggar who received without being able to return but an equal partner with

¹Lala Lajpat Rai: *op. cit.*, pp. 29-30.

other nations; (iv) while learning several valuable lessons from other countries, she had her own unique and valuable contribution to make to World culture and thought; and (v) it is the duty of a national system of education to develop these attitudes of originality and self-respect combined with openness to accept new and useful ideas from *all* sources.

(d) *Domination of English to go*: Fourthly, national education desired to remove the domination of English, particularly its use as a medium of instruction, and to give their proper place to the modern Indian languages. Here the most uncompromising opposition to English came from Mahatma Gandhi. Even at this early period, he put forward the view that Hindustani should be the national language of India and that English should not be a medium of instruction at any stage of education. Of course, his views were not shared by several other leaders. But his extreme position was a natural reaction to the official emphasis on English, and as time passed, Indian opinion began to be influenced more by his views than those of other leaders.

(e) *Vocational Education to be Emphasised*: Fifthly, the failure of the modern system of education to bring about the economic development of the country was greatly condemned, and its growing expensive character was deplored. Indian opinion, therefore, asserted that national education must give due place to vocational education and its cost must be within the reach of the average Indian. Even at the end of this period, however, very little progress was achieved under the official system. Indian public opinion, therefore, began to assert that a national system of education must emphasise the economic development of the country and help to bring it about. Opinions were naturally divided regarding the means whereby this could be done. Some stood for the development of industries through the use of machine power. Others condemned the use of machines on religious and spiritual grounds. The conflict was obviously much too fundamental to have been resolved at this time. But it is interesting to note that Mahatma Gandhi had, as early as 1921, enunciated certain principles which later on became the *Wardha Scheme of Basic Education*.

This fixation of the ideals of national education was probably the simplest of its aspects. Far more difficult were the problems

of organisation and execution connected with the new concept. Institutions imparting national education from the primary to the university stage had to be organised; the teachers required for them had to be obtained and specially trained; new curricula had to be developed; parents had to be persuaded to send their children to the national schools in preference to the official ones; social recognition for the degrees and diplomas granted by the national institutions had to be secured; and the huge funds required for maintaining the national schools on a sufficiently wide scale had to be collected year after year. These were obviously tasks that went far beyond the financial and human resources which the nationalist organisations of the day could command and consequently the whole experiment of national education had to contend against very heavy odds in these early years.

The attempts to start *national schools* fall into two distinct periods. The first upheaval occurred soon after the partition of Bengal. Government issued orders prohibiting students from participating in political meetings and demonstrations. These compelled several students to boycott schools and colleges and several others were rusticated by the authorities for participation in political activities. It was felt to be a national duty to provide for the education of the young men who had thus suffered and hence a *Society for the Promotion of National Education in Bengal* was organised under the chairmanship of Shri Gurudas Banerjee. The movement received great impetus because the Calcutta Congress (1906) resolved that the time had arrived "for the people all over the country earnestly to take up the question of national education for both boys and girls, and organise a system of education, literary, scientific and technical, suited to the requirements of the country, on National lines and under National control, and directed towards the realisation of National destiny". A large number of National High Schools was started by this Society and at one time, there were as many as 11 High Schools in Bengal and 40 in East Bengal.¹ Babu Satish Chandra Mukherjee was the chief worker of this Society which was imparting education in accordance with the Resolution of the Calcutta Congress. Outside Bengal, however, the movement did not spread materially

¹See *Quinquennial Review* (1907-12), para. 670.

—the only institution worth mention being the *Samarth Vidyalyaya* at Talegaon, near Poona. But very soon, a deterioration set in. The political tempo created by the partition died out, particularly after the reunion of Bengal; and as early as 1920, Lala Lajpat Rai was bewailing the disappearance of the National High Schools which were once so popular. He wrote:

The National Council of Education still exists, but only in name. Its condition is moribund. The leaders and officers themselves have strangled it. Mr. T. Palit and Sir Rash Behari Ghosh, two of its strongest pillars, gave it a death-blow when they handed over their magnificent endowment to the Calcutta University, instead of to the National Council of Education, founded and led by them.¹ The few scholars who, with characteristic self-sacrifice, gave up careers to give instruction to the students of the National College, are all dispersed. They are seeking appointments in Government-aided institutions. The Nationalist schools, started by the Council, have, most of them, been disintegrated by the force of circumstances, and at the present moment the movement is nothing but a dilapidated and discarded landmark in the educational progress of the country.²

The second upheaval occurred in 1920-22. In spite of strong opposition from older statesmen like Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya, Mahatma Gandhi started preaching a boycott of Government schools and colleges. It was mainly because of his insistence that the Non-cooperation Resolution passed by the Nagpur Congress in 1920 earnestly advised the "gradual withdrawal of children from schools and colleges owned, aided or controlled by Government, and, in place of such schools and colleges, the establishment of national schools and colleges in the various Provinces".³ This resolution was supported by Gandhiji on three grounds. The first and foremost was the supreme political

¹This has reference to endowments of Rs. 15 lakhs and Rs. 12½ lakhs respectively given to the Calcutta University by Sir Tarak Nath Palit and Sir Rash Behari Ghosh.

²Lala Lajpat Rai: *op. cit.*, pp. 25-26.

³Dr. Pattabhi Sitaramayya: *History of the Indian National Congress*, Vol. I, p. 203.

necessity of the youth fighting for the freedom of their country. The main idea behind his Non-cooperation Movement of 1920-21 was that *Swaraj could be obtained within one year* if the public followed his advice in general and, in particular, completely boycotted the institutions conducted by Government and set up parallel institutions of its own. He desired to create a complete deadlock and paralyse Government by calling upon the people to make a supreme, co-ordinated, and comprehensive effort to non-cooperate with the alien rulers and naturally expected that the youth of the country, which included the students reading in schools and colleges, should take a prominent part in the struggle and sacrifice a year of their life for the cause of national freedom. Secondly, he felt it to be immoral and spiritually degrading that the young men and women of the country should continue to study in the institutions of a Government which was guilty of the Punjab and Khilafat wrongs. And lastly, he was also convinced that, as an emergency measure, the public could really afford to maintain a parallel set of educational institutions—particularly secondary schools and colleges—without any financial assistance from Government.

This appeal of Gandhiji to the youth of the country, which was strongly supported by several other national leaders and in particular, by the Ali Brothers,¹ did not go in vain. In fact, the response of the students to the call for the boycott of schools and colleges was far more successful than any other form of boycott or non-cooperation suggested by the Congress.² The first to come in the field were the students of the Aligarh University. When Mahatma Gandhi and the Ali Brothers visited Aligarh and addressed the students, a tremendous response came forth and the students decided in favour of Non-cooperation and refusal of all Government assistance. Amidst scenes of great enthusiasm, they passed a resolution demanding that the University should be nationalised by disowning all connection with Government and revising its curricula on national lines. But unfortunately, the unity among the students did not last long. Several of them were recalled home by their parents and some others were

¹Maulana Shaukat Ali and Mahomed Ali.

²The only probable exception to this statement may be the No-vote campaign.

persuaded to change their views. A small band of convinced fighters, led by the redoubtable Maulana Mohamed Ali, however, continued to stay on the University premises and to claim that the institution should be fully nationalised according to their demand. This fight continued for some weeks; but at last the Trustees of the University sought police help and turned out all those who were fighting for nationalisation. They left quietly in spite of very great provocation, because non-violent passive resistance was the principal plank of the campaign, and established a new University, the *Jamia Millia Islamia* (National Muslim University) at Aligarh almost immediately.

This splendid lead given by Aligarh was soon picked up in other parts of India. As Dr. Pattabhi Sitaramayya observes:

National Universities, National Colleges, and National Schools of all grades were started in different parts of the country. The student movement in the U.P., the Punjab, and the Bombay Presidency was in full swing. Bengal was not behindhand, and Calcutta witnessed one of those thrilling scenes which were not few or far between in the course of that memorable year and a half. About the middle of January, on an appeal by Deshbandhu C. R. Das, thousands of students left their colleges and examinations. Gandhi visited Calcutta and opened the National College on the 4th of February. He also visited Patna for a second time and formally opened the National College and inaugurated the Bihar Vidyapith. Thus in the course of less than four months, the National Muslim University of Aligarh, the Gujarat Vidyapith, the Bihar Vidyapith, the Kashi Vidyapith, the Bengal National University, the Tilak Maharashtra Vidyapith, and a large number of National Schools of all grades, with thousands of students on the rolls, were started in all parts of the country as a result of the great impetus given to National Education.¹

The difficulties under which the new national institutions laboured can only be imagined. Almost overnight, they had to start functioning as full-fledged educational institutions of a type which had hardly been clearly envisaged in the past. Lack of

¹*History of the Indian National Congress*, Vol I, p. 211.

suitable buildings and equipment and inadequate finances and trained personnel stared them in the face. Moreover, the students and teachers of these institutions were expected to carry on political propaganda among the people, particularly among those living in rural areas, during their vacations and sometimes even during term-time. The opposition from Government was always there and quite frequently, the prominent workers among the students or teachers were arrested on some charge or other and imprisoned. But in spite of all these handicaps and difficulties, the national institutions did yeoman service by formulating the principles of national education, by preparing alternative courses suited to national needs, and by adopting the modern Indian languages as media of instruction. It would be no exaggeration to say that it was in the *laboratory* of these national institutions that the fundamental principles of a national reconstruction of education were first evolved.

Unfortunately, a set-back to the whole movement came in too early. The tempo of the Non-cooperation Movement cooled down after some time, and as some cases of violence began to occur, Gandhiji withdrew the Movement altogether. The fundamental concept of *Swaraj within one year* did not materialise and as the prospect of Independence receded into the background, the enthusiasm of the students naturally began to wane. The national leaders also realised that it would be wrong to expect the students to sacrifice the whole of their career. The earlier policy of non-cooperation was accordingly changed and, excepting a few top-ranking institutions, others were allowed to seek Government recognition again and the students were also permitted, unless they desired to devote their whole life to the national cause, to seek admission to recognised schools and complete their training. By 1922, the tide had almost ebbed.

This second upheaval in national education, as the above account will show, differed materially from the first in several respects. It was more intensive, and more widespread; the numbers of students and teachers involved in it were far larger; it contributed more largely to constructive educational thought; and the movement continued to exist and no useful pioneer work even after non-cooperation came to an end, while the first upheaval hardly left any such mileposts behind. It is also worthy

of note that the upheaval created a new national leadership and "not a few of the Provincial and District leaders of today are from among the . . . students who had non-cooperated in 1920".¹ It also created a wave of patriotic feeling, not only among the students of national institutions, but among the whole of the student community at large. Even the conservative bureaucrats of the I.E.S. were affected considerably and felt that India was not really satisfied with the existing system and that a reconstruction thereof was urgently needed. As the *Quinquennial Review of the Progress of Education in India, 1917-22*, observed:

14. In short . . . the crisis has left behind the conviction that our educational aims need restatement. If the function of education is the adaptation of the future citizen to his environment, then the content of education must change in harmony with changes in that environment. The political and economic conditions of India have been undergoing change and the national school movement can at least claim that it lent strength to the advocates of educational reform.

General Review of the Period from 1855 to 1921: This survey of the principal educational developments in the period from 1905 to 1921 can now be closed with a brief and general review of the educational developments in India as a whole between 1855 and 1921. These sixty-six years are unique in the history of modern education in India. Prior to 1855, the Education Departments did not exist; and in 1921 the control of education was transferred to Indian Ministers responsible to a legislature with a large elected majority. During the interim period of about seven decades, the ultimate authority in education was a bureaucracy—whether it was the bureaucracy of the officers of the Education Departments or ultimately of the I.C.S. It would, therefore, be desirable to evaluate the principal achievements of this *Bureaucratic Raj* in education and to see where exactly the Indian Education Ministers had to begin their work.

(a) *Expansion—its extent and limitations:* It will be seen from the narrative of events contained in this and the three preceding chapters that there was a great expansion of the modern

¹Dr. Patlabhi Sitaramayya: *op. cit.*, p. 211.

system of education between 1854 and 1921. It would, therefore, be interesting to compare the statistics of education in 1855 with those of 1921-22:

	1855	1921-22
1. Universities	—	10
2. Arts Colleges	21	165
3. Professional Colleges (the figures of 1855 under this head include Professional Schools other than Normal Schools)	13	64
4. Secondary Schools	281	7,530
5. Primary Schools	2,810	1,55,017
6. Special Schools	7	3,344
7. Total number of recognised institutions	3,132	1,66,130
8. Total number of scholars in recognised institutions	1,35,079	73,96,560
9. Total expenditure on Education	Rs. 9,99,898	Rs. 17,35,88,099
10. Govt. expenditure on Education	Not known; but most of the above amount was expended by Government.	8,56,01,366

N.B.—The figures for 1855 are taken from the *Report of the Indian Education Commission*, General Table No. 1a. Those for 1921-22 are for British India only, exclusive of Burma.

This expansion of the State system of education is certainly a creditable performance. But one has to remember that there was a considerable set-off to this achievement inasmuch as the indigenous system of education mostly disappeared during the period under review. We saw, in Chapter I, that there is good evidence to believe that, at the beginning of the nineteenth century, almost every village had a school of some sort. This vast system of indigenous education had almost ceased to exist and by 1921-22, the *unrecognised institution*—which term includes

all the *known* educational institutions outside the State system—numbered only 16,322 with only 422,165 pupils. It was mainly because of this set-off that the percentage of literacy given by Adam does not differ materially from that of 1921-22. For instance, take the following statistics:

	<i>Adam's Figures</i> (Taken from his intensive studies of six Thanais in the third report. <i>Vide</i> Chapter I)	<i>Position of</i> <i>British India in</i> <i>1921-22</i> (Burma is excluded.)
(a) Centres of Instruction, i.e., Schools—public and domestic— as given by Adam and schools— recognised and unrecognised— as given in Departmental Reports	2,210 (1 for 225 persons)	1,82,752 (1 for 1,280 persons)
(b) Pupils under instruction	6,786	78,18,725
(c) Percentage of pupils under instruction to the total population (This ought to be about 15 per cent.)	1.4	3.3
(d) Number of Adult literates, ¹ above the age of 15. (Adam's figures are for literates above the age of 14.)	21,911	1,24,60,170
(e) Percentage of Adult literates to the total population	4.4	5.2

¹Figures given here are for whole of British India excluding Ajmere-Merwara, Andamans and Nicobars, British Baluchistan, Coorg and Delhi for which figures are not available.

If allowance is made for the imperfections in Adam's figures, for the fact that education was decaying in the days of Adam, and for the fact that the area surveyed by Adam (which had been under a long period of anarchy) was in all probability more backward in education than other parts of India which had been under a more or less settled government, it will be evident that the educational position of India in 1921-22 was not appreciably different from that in 1821-22, especially if we look at the problem from the point of view of the work that yet remained to be done.

The achievements of the modern system of education, therefore, were hardly of any importance from the *quantitative* point of view. At the beginning of the nineteenth century, when the State had not accepted any responsibility for the education of the people, the cultivation of letters was restricted to a *small minority* of the population, and the vast majority—which included almost all the females—were unable to read and write. Even in 1921-22, there was no material improvement in the situation. Education was still confined to a small minority. The percentage of literacy in India in 1921 was still low, and the vast majority of the people still remained outside the educational system. It is, of course, true that there were a few important gains. For instance, there had been a gradual change in the public attitude to female education and women were now entering educational institutions in ever-increasing numbers. Similarly, there was also an awakening among the less advanced sections of society and pupils belonging to them, were now enrolled in educational institutions in a much larger proportion than a hundred years previously. But without belittling the importance of these achievements, it may be stated that the *spread* of education in 1921-22 was not materially wider than that in 1835-38 and many even considered it disappointing in view of the great expansion achieved by the State system of schools during the period under review.

(b) *Causes of Inadequate Quantitative Expansion:* The educational position in 1921-22, therefore, was, in a way, paradoxical. On the one hand, there had been a considerable expansion of the State system of education. The increase in expenditure from Government funds—from about Rs. 1 lakh in 1821 to Rs. 902 lakhs in 1921—deserves particular notice. On the other hand, the rise in the percentage of population enrolled in schools was not proportionate to the increase in expenditure; nor was the rise in the percentage of literacy proportionate to the rise in the pupils under instruction. As may be easily anticipated, this was the paradox which educationists were called upon to explain.

One school of thinkers tried to explain the situation by pointing out the *intrinsic difficulties of the problem* and the *waste and ineffectiveness* involved in the educational system. According to this school, the slow advance of mass education was due to: